

THE GREEN FUTURE

Engaging Students in Climate Action & Sanitation

A Youth-Led Climate Action Project by Future Forward Development Initiative

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Engaging Secondary School Students in Climate Action and Environmental Sanitation

Background

Gombe State, like many regions across Northern Nigeria, faces significant challenges from environmental degradation and climate change. The impacts are visible in flooding, unusual weather patterns, and widespread environmental destruction. Despite efforts by various organizations, a critical gap remains in awareness and action.

Over 80% of the population in Gombe State lacks foundational knowledge about climate change and its impacts, contributing to continued environmental harm. In educational institutions, poor waste management is particularly problematic, with litter and garbage accumulating throughout school premises.

To address these interconnected challenges, the Youth Leadership Development Programme 2023 Cohort at Gombe State University conceived The Green Future project—an initiative that engages young people in practical, entrepreneurial solutions to environmental problems. The project moves beyond awareness to empower secondary school students with both environmental knowledge and income-generating skills through innovative recycling approaches.

Objectives

The project aimed to:

- Educate young people between ages 16–25 about climate change and environmental preservation
- Equip 500 youth with practical, entrepreneurial skills in waste recycling and sustainable practices
- Demonstrate how recycled materials can create marketable products (e.g., building interlocks from water sachets)
- Promote proper waste disposal and environmental stewardship in educational institutions
- Advance progress toward SDG 1 (No Poverty) and SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth)

Activities

The project was implemented across five secondary schools in Gombe State, targeting over 500 young people. Activities included:

Educational Workshops

Comprehensive workshops held at each participating school to educate students on climate change, environmental preservation, and the personal role young people can play in creating a greener future.

Practical Skills Training: Water Sachet Recycling

Hands-on demonstrations and training sessions teaching students how to transform used pure water sachets and sand into strong, marketable building interlocks. This innovative approach transforms waste into valuable construction materials while generating income opportunities.

Infrastructure and Waste Management

Donation of strategically placed trash cans to each school to promote proper waste disposal and environmental cleanliness. This infrastructure change was paired with awareness-building to establish sustainable habits.

Tree Planting and Environmental Restoration

500 tree seedlings were planted across participating schools, with responsibility for care assigned to both staff and students. Regular monitoring visits tracked growth and reinforced long-term environmental stewardship.

Results and Impact

Reach and Engagement

Over 500 young people between ages 16–25 were directly engaged across five secondary schools in Gombe State.

Key Outcomes

Outcome	Achievement
Entrepreneurial Skills Acquisition	500 youth trained to create marketable products from waste materials, opening pathways to economic empowerment
Environmental Knowledge	Significantly increased awareness of climate change, waste classification (reusable vs. biodegradable), and recycling practices
Sustainable Practices	500 tree seedlings planted; waste disposal infrastructure established; ongoing environmental stewardship
SDG Progress	Advances toward SDG 1 (No Poverty) and SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth)

Media and Documentation

The project was documented through photography, capturing key moments of youth engagement, hands-on training, and environmental action. Below is a photo gallery showcasing the Green Future initiative in action:

Figure 1: Team Green Future Project Presentation



Team members present the Green Future project at Gombe State University, introducing the initiative and its objectives to students and stakeholders.

Figure 2: Hands-on Water Sachet Recycling Training



Students participate in practical training on transforming used water sachets into building interlocks, while tree planting begins in school grounds.

Figure 3: Community Participation and Waste Recycling Demonstration



Team members and students showcase recycled materials and handcrafted products made from waste, demonstrating the entrepreneurial potential of the Green Future approach.

Figure 4: Tree Planting and Environmental Stewardship



Students and facilitators actively plant tree seedlings, marking a commitment to long-term environmental restoration and climate action in their communities.

Lessons Learned

Practical, hands-on approaches to environmental education resonate deeply with young people and translate awareness into action

Linking environmental action to economic opportunity (waste-to-product entrepreneurship) is a powerful motivator for sustained engagement

Institutional support (through schools) is critical for scaling and sustaining environmental initiatives

Infrastructure changes (trash cans, tree protection systems) combined with education create lasting behavioral shifts

Young people are capable and willing environmental leaders when given the knowledge, skills, and platforms to act

Conclusion

The Green Future demonstrated that environmental action and economic empowerment are not competing goals—they are complementary. By equipping 500 young people with both climate literacy and practical recycling skills, the project created pathways to livelihood while advancing environmental sustainability.

The initiative proved that secondary school students can be powerful agents of environmental change, capable of transforming waste into resources and contributing meaningfully to a greener, more sustainable Gombe State. The trees planted, the skills learned, and the awareness created will continue bearing fruit for years to come.

This project exemplifies how youth-led initiatives, grounded in practical solutions and aligned with global sustainable development goals, can catalyze meaningful change at the community level.

Acknowledgment

We extend our gratitude to the five participating secondary schools, all facilitators, volunteers, and community partners who contributed their time, resources, and expertise. Special thanks to the 500 young advocates who brought energy, creativity, and commitment to environmental action. This project would not have been possible without the support of Gombe State University's Youth Leadership Development Programme and the communities that hosted our initiatives.

Together, we are building a greener future for Nigeria and Africa at large.